

SUBHAS BOSE, INDIRA GANDHI, MAULANA GANDHI, R.M. LOHIA, SAROJININ MAITRA, S. NAMBOODIRIPAD, RAJENDRA PRASAD, S. RADHAKRISHNAN, B.C. ROY, BHAGAT SINGH, BAL GANGADHAR TILAK, A.B.A. AMBAYE

to enslave humanity. Its proper name would be infamy.”

ETERNAL FIGHTER

A lawyer by profession, a civil rights activist by choice, a social reformer by nature and a politician by chance, Ambedkar worked against injustice wherever it existed. His slogan was simple: educate, organise and agitate.

■ By David Blundell

Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar rose from the Dalit “undercaste” community (“untouchables” who were known as “depressed classes” and later called “Scheduled Castes”) in India. He received his education in India and the West and became a national leader in the country’s struggle for equality and justice. In Independent India,

of his community. The Maharaja of Baroda noticed his brilliance and gave him a scholarship to Columbia University where he encountered the Afro-American community in Harlem, the United States’s 14th Amendment to Constitution granting equality to all and the views of professors such as John Dewey, who was an American philosopher and education reformer. All these propelled him to campaign for human rights.

After his doctoral studies in economics at Columbia University, he went to England to achieve similar success at

the London School of Economics and passed the Bar at Gray’s Inn. Upon his return to India in 1917, his patron, the Maharaja of Baroda, awarded him a high position in government. He felt obligated at first, but because no other staff in the government office would deal with him as an untouchable, and no lodging was provided to him, he was forced to resign from the post. Later in Bombay, he found low-cost government housing consisting of a small room. He tried his luck in law, but his attention quickly turned to the sufferings of the millions of untouchables.

Ambedkar worked against injustice wherever it existed. His slogan was: educate, organise, agitate. To educate, he taught in colleges, and later built institutions of high learning in Bombay and across Maharashtra. To organise, he became a writer, publisher, social and labour leader, and established political parties. To

agitate, he sparred with other leaders of his time. From 1930-1932, Ambedkar represented the “untouchable population” at the three Round Table Conferences held in London which guaranteed a separate voting franchise to the under-caste from that of the Hindus in 1932. However, Mahatma Gandhi stood against political separation and decided to go on a fast in protest. Gandhi sought indivisible rights for untouchables as part of Hindu society while Ambedkar wanted separate political rights and social reform. As Gandhi fasted, the Poona Pact was reached allowing general voting rights, and not a separate franchise for untouchables.

Ambedkar’s life was dedicated to reform in society. He championed a moral social order against exploitation of people. This egalitarian quest led him to explore various beliefs. He was impressed by Buddha’s teachings and viewed Buddhism as a means of bringing about social change based on individual practice and service to society. He showed the way to his community by embracing Buddhism at Nagpur, Maharashtra, in 1956. He passed away in the same year. The world community has much to gain from understanding his life and his conviction to bring about a social revolution for the dispossessed.

The author earned his doctorate in anthropology at the University of California and is currently at the National Chengchi University, Taiwan. He is working on a film on Ambedkar.

B.R. Ambedkar

Lawyer 1891-1956

Ambedkar was appointed the first law minister. He framed the nation’s Constitution, making it a secular state and provided ideas for national emblems such as the Ashoka lions and the dharma wheel on the national flag.

Ambedkar lived a sheltered childhood on a military base in the late 19th century British India, not really comprehending being an undercaste. Since untouchable children were forbidden education, it was one high caste teacher who noticed his intelligence, guided him, and eventually gave him his own name Ambedkar. In school, he suffered insults and humiliation from other students, yet overcame that to become the first graduate